

"So keeping all this in mind, it becomes a little difficult when you come to the ground on the morning [of the game], and you come to know a player has a niggle, then it's almost like, do you want to take a chance? Some player is 80 per cent fit, you are playing with five bowlers and if this player comes out after bowling five overs, then who will bowl? This is difficult. So, as a group we need improved fitness and all those things," Gill said after the third ODI at Lord's.

There are more names on the list. Upcoming pacers Prince Yadav, Yuvraj Singh and Ashok Sharma, Test regular Akash Deep, and spinner Suyash Sharma have all needed interventions in Bengaluru in 2026 alone.

Naturally, the scopes have been aimed at the CoE for accountability. That the facility has had no head of sports science since Nitin Patel left 18 months ago does not help its case. It needed assurance from CoE head V.V.S. Laxman to allay concerns over the set-up's functioning.

"The CoE is not merely a rehab centre. There are bigger roles to play for it in helping cricketers achieve excellence," he said at a press conference in Bengaluru.

Indian players struggling with fitness is not a recent trend. Bumrah, the team's undisputed pace phenom, has been a regular at the BCCI facility, especially since his back injury during the Border-Gavaskar Trophy in early 2025. Riyan Parag (shoulder) underwent his rehab at the CoE. Mohammed Shami's return after knee surgery following the 2023 World Cup was handled at the CoE's predecessor, the National Cricket Academy, also in Bengaluru.

But the recent troubles, especially with players like Pandya and Reddy getting reinjured, have put question marks over injury management in Indian cricket.

Why is workload so important?

Andrew Leipus, who has twice served as India's head physiotherapist and was a candidate to replace Nitin, however, reasons that the present injury rut is merely a

by-product of a rigorous cricket calendar and external factors that may lead to a player's absence.

"I don't think there's a crisis. All teams go through periodic increases

India injured players and workloads in 2026 (only in games)

Player	Balls	Balls
	bowled	faced
Jasprit Bumrah	666	—
Nitish Kumar Reddy	648	572
Harshit Rana	429	122
Washington Sundar	479	579
Hardik Pandya	466	455
Varun Chakaravathy	652	—

in injury prevalence. When things are going well, sports science or injury science all flies under the radar. It's only when you start to lose that greater attention is paid to what's going on," Leipus tells *Sportstar*.

India is not alone in suffering from injuries. Take any major Test-playing nation with a rigorous calendar, and

Enduring setbacks: Enduring setbacks: Jasprit Bumrah was ruled out of the two-Test series against Sri Lanka, with the left knee niggle he picked up in Cardiff during the second ODI against England in July still refusing to relent. GETTY IMAGES

